



ALTHOUGH THEY ORIGINATE IN THE MOUNTAINS OF CENTRAL ASIA, tulips first arrived in Europe more than 400 years ago as a result of trade with the Ottoman Empire. They became such a desirable status symbol that in the 17th century “Tulipomania” broke out and people began trading bulbs for enormous sums—one buyer exchanged his canal-side house in Amsterdam for a single rare bulb! The Dutch people (and their economy) survived the inevitable crash and created a strong tulip industry that continues to dominate the world market. The Netherlands grows around three billion bulbs each year, of which two billion are exported.

